Hands: For Mothers Day

By Nikki Giovanni

INTRODUCTION

Perhaps you have heard the story of the young boy who always made his mother wear gloves out in public because he was embarrassed at the unsightly deformity of her hands. During a presentation by the teachers and parents at his school, however, he made a discovery that would forever change his perspective.

His mother shared the story that when the young boy was a baby, the family house caught fire in the middle of the night. In her effort to save her baby boy, the mother's hands were badly burned as she fought the flames to rescue him from his crib. The young boy approached his mother with tears streaming down his cheeks, and he slowly removed the gloves from her hands. As he stroked her deformed hands, he said to her, "these scars are symbols of your love for me, and I am so proud of them. To me, they are the most beautiful hands in the world."

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I think hands must be very important . . . Hands: plait hair . . . knead bread . . . spank bottoms . . . wring in anguish . . . shake the air in exasperation . . . wipe tears, sweat, and pain from faces . . . are at the end of arm which hold . . . Yes hands . . . Let's start with the hands . . .

My grandmother washed on Mondays . . . every Monday . . . If you were a visiting grandchild or a resident daughter . . . every Monday morning at 6:00 a.m. . . . mostly in the dark . . . frequently in the cold . . . certainly alone . . . you heard her on the back porch starting to hum . . . as Black Christian ladies are prone to do . . . at threshold . . . some plea to higher beings for forgiveness and the power to forgive . . .

I saw a photograph once of the mother of Emmett Till . . . a slight, brown woman with pill box hat . . . white gloves . . . eyes dark beyond pain . . . incomprehensibly looking at a world that never intended to see her son be a man . . . That same look is created each year . . . without the

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hat and gloves, for mothers seals are not chic . . . at the Arctic Circle . . . That same look is in vogue in Atlanta, Cincinatte, Buffalo . . . for much the same reason. . . During one brief moment, for one passing wrinkle in time, Nancy Reagan wore that look . . . sharing a bond, as yet unconsummated . . . with Betty Shabazz, Jacqueline Kennedy, Coetta King, Ethel Kennedy . . . The wives and mothers are not so radically different . . . It is the hands of the women which massage the balm . . . the ointments . . . the lotions into the bodies for burial . . . It is our hands which: cover the eyes of small children . . . soothe the longing of the brothers . . . make the beds . . . set then tables . . . wipe away our own grief . . . to give comfort to those beyond comfort . . .

I yield from women whose hands are Black and rough . . . The women who produced me are in defiance of Porcelana and Jergens lotion . . . are ignorant of Madge's need to soak their fingernails in Palmolive dishwashing liquid . . . My women look at cracked . . . jagged fingernails that will never be adequately disguised by

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Revlon's new spring reds . . . We of the unacceptably strong take pride in the strength of our hands . . .

Some people think a quilt is a blanket stretched across a Lincoln bed . . . or from frames on a wall . . . a quaint museum piece to be purchased on Bloomingdale's 30-day same-as-cash plan . . . Quilts are our mosaics . . . Michelle-Angelo's contribution to beauty . . . We weave a quilt with dry, rough hands . . . Quilts are the way our lives are lived . . . We survive on patches . . . scraps . . . the leftovers from a materially richer culture . . . the throwaways from those with emotional options . . . We do the far more difficult job of taking that which nobody wants and not only loving it . . . not only seeint its worth . . . but making it lovable . . . and intrinsically worthwhile.

Through trite . . . it's nonetheless true . . . that a little knowledge is a dangerous thing . . . Perhaps pitiful thing would be more accurate . . . through that too is not profound . . . . The more we experience the human drama . . . the more we are to understand . . . that whatever is

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not quite well about us will also not quite go away . . .

Sometimes . . . when it's something like Mother's Day . . . you really do wish you were smart enough to make the pain stop . . . to make the little hurts quit throbbing . . . to share with Star Trek's Spock the ability to touch your fingertips to the temples and make all the dumb . . . ugly . . . sad things of this world ease from memory . . . It's not at all that we fail to forgive others for the hurts we have received . . . we cannot forgive ourselves for the hurts we have meted . . . So . . . of course . . . we use our hands to push away rather than to pull closer . . .

We look . . . in vain . . . for an image of mothers . . . for an analogy for families . . . for a reason to continue . . . We live . . . mostly because we don't know any better . . . as best we can . . . Some of us are lucky . . . we learn to like ourselves . . . to forgive ourselves . . . to care about others . . . Some of us . . . on special occasions . . . watch the ladies in the purple velvet house slippers with the long black dresses come in from Sunday worship and we

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realize **man** never stood up to catch and kill prey . . . . **man** never reared up on his hind legs to free his front parts to hold weapons . . . WOMAN stood to free her hands . . . to hold her young . . . to embrace her sons and lovers . . . WOMAN stood to applause and cheer a delicate mate who needs her approval . . . WOMAN stood to wipe the tears and sweat . . . to touch the eyes and lips . . . that woman stood to free the arms which hold the hands . . . which hold.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nikki Giovanni
Book: The Selected Poems of Nikki Giovanni
ISBN: 978-0688140472
Publisher: Morrow, William and Co
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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